

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, August 18, 2021, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:00 p.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
At-Large Councilor Dale Girard
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor James Contois (joined the meeting via Zoom – home, alone)
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone

Absent:

At-Large Councilor Michael Demars
At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager
Lisa Richmond, Finance Director

Announcement

Mr. Morris talked about the COVID-19 rates in Claremont and that the CDC (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention) recommends that all people wear masks inside public buildings. Based on the increased COVID numbers in Claremont and the change for Sullivan County to Substantial Transmission, the City is recommending that all people (vaccinated or not) wear masks while in public City buildings. When Sullivan County moves to the moderate range for two weeks or more, then the recommendation can be relaxed.

CITIZEN’S FORUM

No one spoke.

OLD BUSINESS

Sustainable Workforce Compensation Discussion

Mr. Morris put the following requests to the City Council in the Council packet:

- Decide on a compensation philosophy of how it would like to pay City personnel by determining what percentile, based on the Compensation Study presented by Paypoint HR, they would like a plan to be based on.
- Update the non-union pay scale to include the new grading system prepared by Paypoint HR, and to raise the pay scale, while maintaining a consistent spread and ladders between and within grades, in an effort to allow all employees the ability to receive raises, when appropriate.
- Authorize the non-union employee pay scale to be adjusted annually in direct relation to the cost of living based on the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics CPI for the Northeast Region.

Also in the packet was the minutes from the December 1, 2020, Personnel Advisory Board (PAB) meeting where the PAB voted to recommend to the City Council implementation of the salary study at the 40th to 45th percentile of the market rate with the goal of doing it over a period of 5 years.

Councilors asked questions and received answers regarding the Paypoint HR Pay and Classification Study 2020.

Mr. Morris asked the Council about its philosophy regarding pay percentiles. He asked Councilors at what percentile they want City employee pay to be.

Councilor Contois said he thought the compensation study was useless. He said there are five unions in the City and pay is part of the negotiations. He talked about the \$1.3 million it would cost to pay all employees at the 50th percentile. He talked about Claremont's demographics versus the other communities in the study, the valuation rates, and the pay rates in some of those other communities that Claremont cannot compete with. He talked about needing a \$15 minimum wage.

Assistant Mayor Damren said he feels the compensation study is valuable as it represents a look at the surrounding area. Claremont has lost people to other communities, such as Lebanon. He's not willing to take the study at face value; there has to be a balance. Many things are involved in negotiating contracts (i.e. health and dental benefits). He believes our employees are underpaid. It is up to the Council to discuss this.

Mr. Morris said the study is a data point comparison of cities/towns Claremont competes with. He doesn't think it needs to implement it as written. He thinks the City needs to fix the Merit Plan pay scale compression and inequities. He said he would like to know the Council's pay philosophy going forward. One of his goals is to treat all employees as fairly as possible.

Councilor Koloski agreed with some of Assistant Mayor Damren's comments. He would have liked to see some numbers around the 40th percentile (above & below).

Mayor Lovett said that after reading the document, that there are some terrible discrepancies. There are certain segments of the administration that are very far behind in pay. She asked the Council if there was a consensus that there are some major compensation inequities. Councilors agreed with that.

Mr. Morris said he would consider focusing on the employees that are the farthest behind. He asked what percentile the Council would support. He acknowledged that the City has many issues in many areas, including road issues.

Mr. Morris said the City is trying to find savings with the benefit plan. Also, benefits and pay need to be looked at as a whole for compensation.

Councilor Girard said the City pays 80% of the health benefit for new employees and the average community in this study pays 67%.

Mr. Morris talked about employees resigning because of unfair pay and that he can get some data for the Council.

Councilor Stone asked regarding minimum wage how many were full-time versus part-time employees. Mr. Morris said they are all part-time.

Mr. Morris said that many long-term employees have had periods without raises.

There was a discussion about not wanting to reduce benefits in order to increase compensation.

Also, Claremont gives longevity payments, but not all other communities do.

Assistant Mayor Damren and Mayor Lovett think this needs to be a two-phased approach. Try to find out what is fair as far as salaries are concerned and then analyze the benefits.

Councilor O'Hearne said the City Manager needs to work to bring the fairness back. He asked which group of employees has the greatest discrepancies. Mayor Lovett said the greatest discrepancies are with Merit Plan employees. Mr. Morris said most all of the City employees are below based on the compensation study.

Mr. Morris talked about adjusting the Merit Plan pay scale using the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics CPI for the Northeast Region. He would get the figures in January, which would be in time for the budget process. He said some of the union contracts have automatic pay increases (longevity) in them and some do not.

Mr. Morris will work up a pay scale based on the 35th percentile and will put a proposal together with that information. He also asked that the Merit Plan pay scale continues to increase. Moving the scale would not guarantee that employees would receive pay increases, unless they

are stuck at the bottom of the scale. However, it gives the City room to give raises, if appropriate.

Councilor Contois said the City Manager needs to differentiate longevity from cost-of-living adjustments.

Mayor Lovett asked if anyone from the public wanted to say anything about the discussion. No one spoke.

Mr. Morris will look to see when he can get the information together and will let the Council know when it will be back on the agenda.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None.

ADJOURNMENT

At 7:10 p.m., a motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to adjourn.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Damren - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 7-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council